

Photo by BVLGARI

Although gemstones such as rubies, emeralds and sapphires have featured in timepieces of the Art Deco era in the early 1920s, they mainly served as accents. The brand credited for first bringing hardstones to the forefront in watches was Piaget, who launched a vibrant collection in 1963 featuring slices of lapis lazuli, opal, malachite, tiger's eye, and more, just 1mm thick. This was a pivotal moment because up until then using a stone dial required a thicker case, and the wastage in slicing and shaping delicate gem material was an obstacle for most in the watch industry. Piaget was able to break through this barrier because of their ultra-thin 2mm thick calibre 9P movement, launched in 1957.

What Piaget pioneered, the rest of the industry embraced a decade later as a reaction to the first commercially available quartz wristwatch by Japanese watchmaker, Seiko. Vintage watch specialist Louis Briscoe, founder of Louis and Company, explains: "When battery-powered quartz watches arrived in the early 1970s, they changed everything. Cheaper, more accurate, and produced by the millions, they pushed the Swiss watch industry into what became known as the Quartz Crisis.

Some of the great maisons responded in the only way quartz couldn't compete, and that's imagination. Chopard and Piaget embraced natural precious materials such as coral, lapis lazuli, malachite, and tiger's eye, but they weren't the only ones. From Omega and Jaeger-LeCoultre to Audemars Piguet



Photo by PIAGET

Clockwise from left: Bvlgari's Notte Stellata Divas'Dream High-Jewellery watch; Bvlgari's Pavone Bracelet High-Jewellery watch in white gold with white diamonds, rubellites and emeralds; Piaget's Andy Warhol Watch 'Collage' Limited Edition timepiece (50 pieces); The Bvlgari Serpenti Dea Secret High Jewellery watch featuring emeralds and diamonds



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